Future Me

A money game about the person you are becoming. Concept document, production plan and budget for Zoud GameLab — “Make FinLit Fun”.

One line: You have just started your first job. Every month you give each coin of your salary a job, life happens, and once a year a letter arrives from *Future You* — the person your habits are building.
Platform: browser (desktop and mobile), single HTML file, works offline · **Languages:** English and Arabic (full right-to-left) · **Currency:** AED (Dubai setting) or USD · **Session:** 6 minutes (1-year mode) or 15 minutes (3-year mode) · **Audience:** 16–30, especially young adults receiving their first salary.

1. Why this game

Most young people learn money the hard way: the first credit card, the first surprise bill, the first “buy now, pay later” plan. *Future Me* lets players make those mistakes in a safe place, see the consequences a few months later, and connect today's choices to a person they care about — their future self. Research on “future self-continuity” suggests that people who feel connected to their future self save more; the game turns that idea into its central character.

2. Core loop

1. **Payday.** The salary arrives. Rent, transport, subscriptions, the card minimum and any instalments leave automatically.
2. **Give every coin a job.** The player fills six jars — Groceries (need), Fun (want), Emergency fund, Goal jar, Long-term investing, Extra card payment. A “Try 50/30/20” helper shows a common starting rule; the player adjusts it. Money left unassigned in the wallet partly “leaks away” at month end, which teaches the habit of a zero-based budget.
3. **Life happens.** One or two event cards with real choices: a car repair, a phishing text, a friend asking for a loan, a phone on “pay later”, Eid spending, family needing help back home, a market crash, a layoff.
4. **End of month.** Card interest is charged, savings earn profit, investments move, wellbeing changes. A **Money Health score** (0–100) explains itself in five parts.
5. **Once a year: a letter from Future You.** The letter and Future You's face change with the player's habits, with a 10-year projection.

3. Financial literacy built into the mechanics

Concept	How the player meets it
Budgeting, needs vs wants	Six jars every payday; underfunding groceries lowers wellbeing; cutting all fun triggers a burnout splurge event later.
Zero-based budgeting	Unassigned wallet money partly disappears at month end (“give every coin a job”).

Emergency fund	A jar with a visible 3-month target. Repairs, dental bills and a 2-month layoff draw on it first; if it is empty, costs go on the card.
Compound interest on debt	The starting card balance grows 2% a month. The minimum payment trap is visible; total interest paid is reported in letters and at the end.
Buy now, pay later	Instalments appear as fixed bills on the next four paydays.
Very high-cost short-term loans	A “get paid early” app: borrowing 300 to repay 345 next month is shown as over 180% a year.
Fraud and phishing	A fake bank text in month 1; entering details loses money.
Investing, risk and time	Monthly returns vary; a 25% crash asks the player to sell or hold; holding is followed by recovery. Speculative “sure thing” coins usually lose.
Inflation	Grocery costs rise; the player can adapt by planning meals.
Insurance and risk pooling	Optional cover changes the cost of a later dental bill.
Employer match, human capital	Joining the workplace plan doubles contributions; a course can lead to a raise, with a “save the raise” lesson.
Opportunity cost, recurring costs, seasonal costs	Paying from the goal jar delays the goal; subscription audit; Eid and summer electricity as predictable “sinking fund” costs.

4. Educational design

- **Learn by consequence, then explain.** Every choice shows its result first, then a short “money notebook” lesson in plain language.
- **Transparent scoring.** Money Health has five visible parts — spending less than earning, emergency fund, low debt, saving rate and wellbeing — so players see *why* they did well or badly.
- **Retention.** Every lesson the player unlocked is collected in the Money Notebook on the final screen, followed by a three-question check.
- **Balanced, not preachy.** Wellbeing is part of the score: a budget with no fun breaks down. The game respects family support and celebrations as real priorities and teaches how to plan for them.

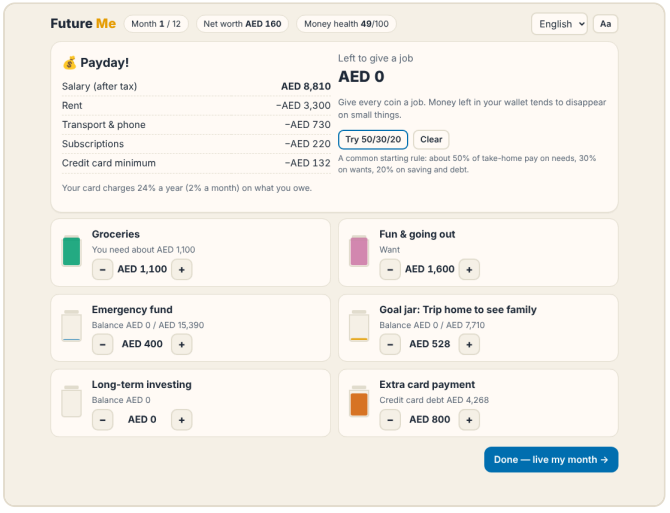
5. Regional perspective and localization

- Full Arabic translation with right-to-left layout, switchable at any time; AED amounts in the Dubai setting.
- Regional situations: Eid gifts and *Eidiya*, sending money to family back home, high summer electricity bills, rent increases, a workplace savings plan.
- Neutral wording for savings returns (“savings profit”). In full production, a Sharia-compliant savings and investing mode would be designed with a qualified scholar and a UAE financial educator (see roadmap).

6. Inclusivity and accessibility

- Colour-blind-safe palette (Okabe–Ito); information is never shown by colour alone.
- Settings for larger text, high contrast, dark mode, reduced motion and sound; follows the system's reduced-motion and dark-mode settings.
- Every control works with a keyboard and has a visible focus style; live regions announce changes for screen readers.
- No timers or reflex skills; plain-language text; works on low-end phones and offline.

7. Current prototype (submitted)





Prototype contents: 24 event cards with branching choices, 1-year and 3-year modes, 3 savings goals, yearly letters, notebook and quiz, English and Arabic, AED and USD. Tested with automated play-throughs (good, poor and random strategies) for stability and balance.

8. Commercial potential

- **Free for players, no ads, no data collection** — trust is essential for a money game.
- **Licensing:** white-label versions for banks and employers (financial wellbeing programmes for new hires), and school/university licences with a teacher pack.
- **Sponsorship:** a national or institutional partner can fund localized editions (e.g. UAE, KSA, Egypt) without changing the game's neutrality.
- **Growth:** new “life chapters” (first car, marriage costs, starting a business), new careers and cities, classroom mode with aggregate (anonymous) results.

9. Production plan — full version (6 months)

Month	Milestone
1	Design lock with a financial educator; content map of 60 events; art direction; Arabic writer onboard.
2–3	Illustrated characters and Future You animations; 3-year campaign; careers and city variants; save/continue.
3	Sharia-compliant mode designed and reviewed; classroom mode and teacher pack.
4	Playtests with 3 schools/universities and one employer group; pre/post knowledge survey.
5	Accessibility audit (WCAG 2.2 AA); performance on low-end Android; offline PWA.
6	Launch on web, Android and iOS (wrapper); impact report from playtests.

10. Budget — full version

Item	Detail	USD
Game design & development	1 lead developer/designer, 6 months	36,000
Art & animation	Illustrator/animator, 4 months	16,000
Arabic writing & cultural review	Native Arabic game writer, all content	6,000
Financial literacy & Sharia review	Certified educator + scholar consultation	5,000
Sound & music	Licensed music, original UI sounds	2,500
QA & accessibility testing	Devices, screen readers, audit	4,000
Playtests & impact study	3 schools + 1 employer, surveys	3,000
Publishing & tools	Store fees, hosting, software	1,500
Contingency	10%	7,400
Total		**81,400**

A smaller first milestone (months 1–3: content, art, Arabic, review) can be delivered for about USD 40,000.

11. Honesty notes

The game simplifies real finance for learning: interest, returns and prices are illustrative, not advice or forecasts. The 10-year projection uses an assumed 7% yearly return and is labelled as a teaching estimate. AI disclosure: the prototype's code, text, Arabic translation and simple vector art were made with AI assistance (Claude) and tested with automated play-throughs; full production would use human writers, artists and reviewers listed in the budget.